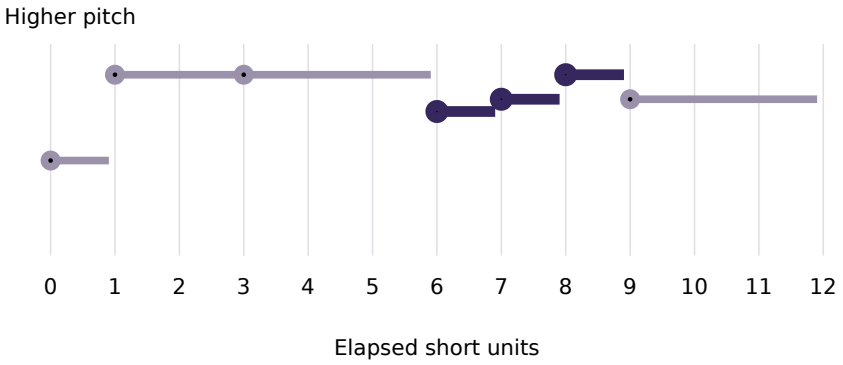
Read the Seikilos song

Selected: verse 1, φαί in φαίνου. Starting A = 440 Hz; 180 short units per minute.

This is a modern listening realization in equal temperament, using sine tones. The stone does not specify this reference pitch, tempo or timbre. The duration reading follows the modern transcription linked below.





Highlighted evidence in the unchanged photograph by Lennart Larsen / National Museum of Denmark, AS-10006, object 14897. CC BY-SA 4.0. The display crops the image and adds a selection rectangle; the embedded photograph is unchanged. This image and its annotated presentation retain that license.

Verse 1

ὅσον ζῇς φαίνου

hoson zēis phainou

As long as you live, shine.

Syllables and our playback reading

Syllable	Pitch signs	Modern pitches	Short units	Hz
ὅ	C	A4	1	440.000
σον	Z	E5	2	659.255
ζῇς	Z	E5	3	659.255
φαί	K → I → Z	C♯5 → D5 → E5	1 + 1 + 1	554.365 → 587.330 → 659.255
νου	I	D5	3	587.330

Verse 2

μηδὲν ὅλως σὺ λυποῦ

mēden holōs sy lypou

Do not grieve at all.

Syllables and our playback reading

Syllable	Pitch signs	Modern pitches	Short units	Hz
μη	K	C♯5	2	554.365
δὲν	I	D5	1	587.330
ὅ	Z	E5	1	659.255
λως	I → K	D5 → C♯5	1 + 1	587.330 → 554.365
σὺ	O	B4	1	493.883
λυ	C	A4	2	440.000
ποῦ	O → Φ	B4 → G4	1 + 2	493.883 → 391.995

Verse 3

πρὸς ὀλίγον ἔστι τὸ ζῆν

pros oligon esti to zēn

Living lasts a little while.

Syllables and our playback reading

Syllable	Pitch signs	Modern pitches	Short units	Hz
πρὸς	C	A4	1	440.000
ὀ	K	C♯5	1	554.365
λί	Z	E5	1	659.255
γον	I	D5	1	587.330
ἔσ	K → I	C♯5 → D5	1 + 1	554.365 → 587.330
τι	K	C♯5	1	554.365
τὸ	C	A4	2	440.000
ζῆν	O → Φ	B4 → G4	1 + 2	493.883 → 391.995

Verse 4

τὸ τέλος ὁ χρόνος ἀπαιτεῖ

to telos ho chronos apaitei

Time demands the end.

Syllables and our playback reading

Syllable	Pitch signs	Modern pitches	Short units	Hz
τὸ	C	A4	1	440.000
τέ	K	C♯5	1	554.365
λος	O	B4	1	493.883
ὁ	I	D5	1	587.330
χρό	Z	E5	1	659.255
νος	K	C♯5	1	554.365
ἀ	C	A4	1	440.000
παι	C	A4	2	440.000
τεῖ	C → X → reversed gamma	A4 → F♯4 → E4	1 + 1 + 1	440.000 → 369.994 → 329.628

Word by word

ὅσον — as long as. A time expression introducing the clause ‘as long as you live’.

ζῇς — you live. From ζάω, to live: present indicative, second person singular. Compare the infinitive ζῆν in verse 3.

φαίνου — shine; show yourself. An imperative addressed to one person. Its first syllable, φαί, carries three rising pitches.

μηδὲν — not at all. Literally ‘nothing’, used here with the prohibition. The negative belongs with λυποῦ, ‘grieve’.

ὅλως — at all; entirely. An adverb strengthening the negative expression. The syllable λως carries two pitches.

σὺ — you. The singular pronoun explicitly addresses the listener. Greek can leave this subject implicit, so its presence is emphatic.

λυποῦ — grieve; be distressed. A present middle/passive imperative from λυπέω, used here with a negative. Two falling pitches share ποῦ, the syllable with a circumflex.

πρὸς — for. With ὀλίγον it forms a time expression: ‘for a little while’.

ὀλίγον — a little. Here, a short amount of time. The word crosses a physical line on the stone between λί and γον.

ἔστι — is; exists. From εἰμί, to be. The subject is τὸ ζῆν, ‘living’. The accented reading is editorial; the stone has capital letters.

τὸ — the. The neuter singular article turns the infinitive ζῆν, ‘to live’, into the noun-like expression ‘living’.

ζῆν — to live; living. The infinitive of ζάω. With τὸ it names the activity of living. Its circumflex syllable has a falling pair of pitches.

τὸ — the. Here the neuter article belongs to τέλος, the object of ‘demands’.

τέλος — end; completion. The object is placed before the subject: ‘the end, time demands’. English normally reverses that order.

ὁ — the. The masculine singular article belongs to χρόνος, the subject of the final clause.

χρόνος — time. The subject of ἀπαιτεῖ. Follow the word across two physical lines: χρό at the end of one, νος at the start of the next.

ἀπαιτεῖ — demands; claims as due. From ἀπαιτέω, present indicative, third person singular. The last syllable has three falling pitches. Its final sign is a reversed gamma, not a square bracket.

Greek is normalized with accents, breathing marks, word divisions and four verse lines. The photograph preserves six physical song lines. Roman letters are a reading aid, not recorded pronunciation. English and notes are new teaching translations; no Latin translation survives on this object.

Armand D’Angour, “The Song of Seikilos” (2021): the modern pitch/duration transcription used here. D. B. Monro, The Modes of Ancient Greek Music (1894), p. 145: correction of the final pitch sign; its rhythm differs from our playback. The museum catalogues the stele as Roman-period Greek; date and dedication have interpretive uncertainties.

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